

PROLOGUE

The Roman Empire was the strongest force the world had ever seen.

From the mist-shrouded shores of Britannia to the sun-scorched sands of Aegyptus, from the frozen rivers of Germania to the spice-trade ports of the Orient, the Eagle flew. Its legions marched in lockstep, their sandals pounding the earth in a rhythm that made kings tremble and nations crumble. Its roads stretched across continents straight, unyielding, eternal carrying soldiers, merchants, slaves, and the relentless will of the Senate and People of Rome.

Seventy million souls lived beneath its shadow. Some prospered. Some suffered. All obeyed.

The Empire had faced enemies without number Gauls, Britons, Parthians, Dacians, Egyptians, Jews, Germans, Carthaginians, Greeks. It had crushed them all. It had absorbed their lands, their wealth, their gods. It had remade the world in its own image.

But beneath the marble and the gold, beneath the triumph arches and the victory columns, there were things that the histories did not record. There were stories that soldiers told in the darkness of their tents, when the wine had loosened their tongues and the fires had burned low. Stories of men who had walked through the gates of Hell and returned with something terrible in their eyes.

The Empire did not speak of them openly. But every soldier knew.

The taberna sat at the edge of the frontier fort a cramped, filthy hole of smoke-stained walls and packed dirt floors. The roof leaked. The wind howled through the gaps in the shutters. It was the kind of place where men went to forget.

The soldiers huddled around a low table, their faces illuminated by a single guttering oil lamp. They were young fresh recruits sent to the frontier to prove themselves. They had marched, trained, stood guard. They had not seen war. Not really. They had never watched a man die up close.

They had not seen him.

"Tell us again," one of them said. A boy, barely seventeen. His voice was eager, hungry for something to believe in. "Tell us about the about the Spartan."

The old soldier did not respond.

He sat alone at the edge of the firelight, his back against the wall, his hands wrapped around a cup of wine that he had not touched. He was young younger than the others, perhaps but his eyes were not young. They were hollow. Dead. The kind of eyes that had seen too much and could not look away.

His name was Valerius. He had been a soldier once a good one, they said. He had fought in the Parthian campaigns, earned his citizenship through blood and service. He had been promoted. Decorated. He had been on the path to glory.

Then he had seen the Spartan.

Now he sat in taverns, drinking wine he did not drink, staring at walls he did not see. The other soldiers mocked him. They called him Valerius the Mad. Valerius the Liar. Valerius the Fool. They did not believe his stories.

They had not been there.

"I've heard it before," another soldier said. A young woman, her hair cropped short, her face hard. She was a scout, one of the best. She had survived three ambushes, two skirmishes, and one full-scale battle. She was not easily frightened. "The Spartan. The demon. The man who cannot be killed."

She laughed a hard, bitter sound. "Every legion has a ghost story. Every legion has a man who "

"Shut your mouth."

The words came from the corner. From him.

Valerius had not moved. His eyes were still fixed on the wall. But his voice his voice had changed. It was low. Rough. Cold.

"You were not there," he said. "You did not see what I saw."

The tavern fell silent. The soldiers exchanged glances. They had seen Valerius angry before but this was different. This was not anger. This was something older. Something darker.

One of the younger soldiers leaned forward. His name was Cassius. Brave, or foolish, or both.

"Then tell us," he said. "Tell us what you saw."

Valerius was silent for a long moment. The wind howled outside. The lamp flickered.

"I was with the legion on the frontier," he said slowly. "Pannonian territory. The tribes had been restless for months. They attacked without warning came down from the mountains at dawn, thousands of them. We were outnumbered ten to one. The general ordered a retreat. We couldn't. They had us surrounded."

He took a drink of wine. For the first time, he actually swallowed it.

"The Spartan was with us. I didn't know him. No one did. He kept to himself. He didn't talk. He just fought. And when the line broke, when the men ran, he stayed. He held the center alone. Ten men. Twenty. Fifty. He killed them all."

Cassius shook his head. "That's impossible. No one can "

"They didn't kill him," Valerius said. "They captured him. They wanted to make an example. They stripped him. Beat him. Burned him. They did things to him that I cannot that I will not describe. He should have died. A hundred times over, he should have died."

His voice dropped.

"But he didn't. Because something... something came to him in the darkness. In the place between life and death. It offered him a choice. Death... or something else. Something terrible."

The room went cold.

"He chose the terrible thing."

Valerius's hand shook. He steadied it.

"I was hiding in the shadows. I had been wounded I couldn't run. I watched him stand up, naked and broken, and I saw his chains shatter. Not through strength. Through something else. Something that had come from that place."

He looked up. His eyes were wet.

"He killed them. All of them. With his bare hands. I saw his face his eyes. They were blue. Not the blue of the sky. Not the blue of the sea. They were the blue of Hell. The blue of something that had been waiting for a very long time."

The tavern was silent.

"The blood " Valerius's voice cracked. "It was everywhere. On the walls. On the ground. On him. He was covered in it, head to foot. But he didn't stop. He didn't even seem to notice. He just kept killing. His hands I saw him tear a man's throat out with his teeth. I saw him rip another man's arm from its socket and beat him to death with it. He was not human anymore. He was something else."

Cassius's face had gone pale. The others were silent too.

"I ran," Valerius said. "I should have stayed. I should have died. But I ran. I was the only one who survived."

He sat back. His hands were shaking.

"His men the ones who survived, the ones who saw him after they were not afraid of him. Do you understand me? They had seen him kill hundreds. They had seen what he had become. And they were not afraid. They followed him. They worshiped him."

Cassius licked his lips. "That's that's just a story. A legend. It can't be "

"You think I'm lying?" Valerius's voice rose. "You think I made this up? I was there. I watched him die. I watched him come back. And I have never fought again. I cannot. Every time I close my eyes, I see him. Every time I sleep, I dream of those blue eyes. They are watching me. They are always watching."

The soldiers exchanged uncomfortable glances. Some looked away. Others stared at the floor.

Cassius laughed a nervous, desperate sound. "You're insane. You're "

"I know what I saw." Valerius's voice was quiet now. Dead. "I know what I saw, and I know what he is. He is out there. Somewhere. Waiting. And when he comes again when Rome falls you will remember this night. You will remember my words. And you will know that I was not lying."

He stood.

The soldiers pressed back from him as if he were a giant. He was not tall. Not strong. But there was something in his eyes something that made them afraid.

He walked to the door.

He paused.

"He will come again," Valerius said. "The thing in the darkness saved him for a reason. And when the time comes when the Empire's enemies gather at its gates he will return. Not to save Rome. To destroy it. To burn it. To end it. He is not a hero. He is the Devil's Spartan."

He walked out into the rain.

The tavern fell silent.

The soldiers stared at the door.

And somewhere, in the darkness beyond the frontier, a pair of blue eyes opened.